

Chapter 1 — Introduction: How, When and Where

The one-line point: The British wrote down **everything** — and that is both the historian's greatest resource and their biggest trap. This chapter teaches you to read colonial records **against the grain**, and it demolishes **James Mill's** periodisation for good.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Modern India
Sub-discipline	Historiography & colonial knowledge
Period	Frames c. 1750 – 1947
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → sources, surveys, census, periodisation
Mains (GS Paper I)	★★ Supplies the critical framing for every colonial-era answer; " colonial " vs " modern " is directly quotable
Also feeds	Indian Society ★★ (the census and the hardening of caste identity), Polity (the colonial state's information order), Essay ★ (knowledge and power)
Weightage	★★★ — few direct questions, but it makes the rest of the book intelligible
Overlaps with	Class 7 Ch.1 (the same periodisation critique, from the other side)

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain** why fixing precise dates to historical *processes* is misleading. ★
- ☐ **State James Mill's** periodisation, its date, its assumptions, and **four objections** to it. ★★★
- ☐ **Explain** why many historians prefer "**colonial**" to "modern" for this period. ★★
- ☐ **Define colonisation** as NCERT does.
- ☐ **Describe** the colonial **record-keeping apparatus** — record rooms, archives, calligraphists, printed proceedings. ★
- ☐ **List** the kinds of **survey** the British conducted and explain **why**. ★★
- ☐ **State what official records do NOT tell us**, and name the alternative sources. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** the limitation that even those alternatives share. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** why the book is titled *Our Pasts* in the **plural**. ★

Start Here: When Did Indians Start Drinking Tea?

NCERT opens with a deceptively simple question. **You cannot answer it with a date.**

*"People in India did not begin drinking tea one fine day; they developed a taste for it over time. **There can be no one clear date for a process such as this.**"*

And the same is true of the things this book is actually about:

THINGS THAT HAVE NO SINGLE DATE

- the establishment of British rule
- the start of the national movement
- changes within the economy and society

"All these things happened over a **STRETCH** of time.
We can only refer to a **SPAN** of time, an **APPROXIMATE PERIOD** over which particular changes became visible."

★ ★ So why is history still associated with dates?

Because *"there was a time when history was an account of **battles and big events**. It was about **rulers and their policies**."* Historians wrote the year a king was crowned, married, fought, died, and was succeeded.

But NCERT's key methodological point is about *selection*:

★ "The dates we select... are not important on their own. They become vital because we focus on a particular set of events as important. **IF OUR FOCUS OF STUDY CHANGES, IF WE BEGIN TO LOOK AT NEW ISSUES, A NEW SET OF DATES WILL APPEAR SIGNIFICANT.**"

The worked example NCERT gives:

BRITISH HISTORIES OF INDIA were organised around the rule of each GOVERNOR-GENERAL:

Warren Hastings -> Wellesley -> Bentinck -> Dalhousie ->
Canning -> Lawrence -> Lytton -> Ripon -> Curzon ->
Harding -> Irwin ... ending with the last Viceroy,
Lord MOUNTBATTEN

"All the dates in these history books were linked to these PERSONALITIES -- to their activities, policies and achievements. It was as if there was NOTHING OUTSIDE THEIR LIVES that was important for us to know."

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"In the histories that revolve around the life of British Governor-Generals, THE ACTIVITIES OF INDIANS SIMPLY DO NOT FIT, THEY HAVE NO SPACE."

 **The chapter structure determined what could be recorded.** Organise the narrative around eleven officials and there is **no field in the schema** for a peasant revolt, a weaver's decline or a reform movement. **Changing the questions requires changing the framework, not just adding facts.**

★ Warren Hastings became the first Governor-General in 1773 — a fact worth carrying.

1 ★ ★ ★ James Mill and the Problem of Periodisation

The most examinable section of the chapter.

Fact	Detail
Who	★ JAMES MILL , a Scottish economist and political philosopher
★ What and when	In 1817 he published a massive three-volume work, <i>A History of British India</i>
★★ His periodisation	He divided Indian history into three periods: HINDU, MUSLIM and BRITISH
Its reception	" <i>This periodisation came to be widely accepted.</i> "

★★ Mill's actual argument — know it, because the critique depends on it

- He thought "**all Asian societies were at a lower level of civilisation than Europe**"
- Before the British came, "***Hindu and Muslim despots ruled the country***"
- "***Religious intolerance, caste taboos and superstitious practices dominated social life***"
- ★ **British rule, Mill felt, could CIVILISE India** — by introducing **European manners, arts, institutions and laws**
- ★ He therefore **suggested the British should conquer ALL the territories of India** "to ensure the enlightenment and happiness of the Indian people"
- "***For India was not capable of progress without British help.***"

IN THIS IDEA OF HISTORY:

British rule = ALL the forces of PROGRESS and CIVILISATION
The period before = ONE OF DARKNESS

★★★★ **This is the intellectual foundation of the "civilising mission"** — the claim that conquest was a service. Mill's book was a **textbook for East India Company officials**, so this was not private opinion; **it was the training material of the colonial administration.**

★★ The objections — NCERT's own questions, answered

#	Objection
1	★ Can we refer to any period as "Hindu" or "Muslim"? " <i>Did not a variety of faiths exist simultaneously in these periods?</i> "
2	★ Why characterise an age only through the religion of the rulers? " <i>To do so is to suggest that the lives and practices of the others do not really matter.</i> "
3	★ "Even rulers in ancient India did not all share the same faith."
4	The scheme was built to justify conquest — it makes British rule the necessary cure for a diseased past

🔗 You met this critique from the medieval side in **Class 7 Ch.1**. Here you get **who made it, when, in what book, and why** — the full case. **Learn Mill's name and the year 1817.**

★★ And the problem with "ancient / medieval / modern" too

Moving away from the British classification, historians usually divide Indian history into **ancient, medieval and modern**. ★ **"This division too has its problems."**

The problem

It is **borrowed from the West**, where "**modern**" was associated with **science, reason, democracy, liberty and equality**

"**Medieval**" described a society where those features **did not exist**

★ ★ But under British rule "people did not have equality, freedom or liberty. **NOR WAS THE PERIOD ONE OF ECONOMIC GROWTH AND PROGRESS.**"

★ ★ ★ Hence: "Many historians therefore refer to this period as **COLONIAL.**"

🎯 This is a superb, precise point and directly usable. Calling 1750–1947 "modern" **imports a claim of progress that the evidence contradicts.** "Colonial" describes the period by **its actual defining relationship** — subjugation — rather than by a borrowed and flattering label. **Periodisation is never neutral** (Class 7 Ch.1), and here is the proof applied to our own textbooks.

★ ★ What "colonisation" means — NCERT's definition

"When the subjugation of one country by another leads to these kinds of **POLITICAL, ECONOMIC, SOCIAL and CULTURAL** changes, we refer to the process as **COLONISATION.**"

The specific changes listed: the British **subjugated local nawabs and rajas, established control over the economy and society, collected revenue to meet all their expenses, bought the goods they wanted at low prices, produced crops they needed for export, and changed values and tastes, customs and practices.**

★ Why "Our PastS" — plural

"You will, however, find that **ALL CLASSES AND GROUPS DID NOT EXPERIENCE THESE CHANGES IN THE SAME WAY.** That is why the book is called **Our PastS IN THE PLURAL.**"

🎯 A one-line title explaining an entire methodological stance. There is no single Indian experience of colonialism — the zamindar, the weaver, the tribal, the widow and the sepoy each lived a different one. **Quote this when a question asks about the "impact of British rule".**

2 ★★ How Do We Know? — The Colonial Archive

📄 Administration produces records

Feature	Detail
★ The belief	"The British believed that the act of writing was important . Every instruction, plan, policy decision, agreement, investigation had to be clearly written up " — so things could be properly studied and debated
The culture it produced	★ "An administrative culture of memos, notings and reports "
★ Record rooms	Attached to all administrative institutions — the village tahsildar's office, the collectorate, the commissioner's office, the provincial secretariats, the lawcourts
Specialised institutions	★ Archives and museums established to preserve important records
★ Calligraphists	In the early nineteenth century documents were copied out and beautifully written by calligraphists — specialists in the art of beautiful writing
★ Printing	By the middle of the nineteenth century , with the spread of printing, multiple copies were printed as proceedings of each government department
The National Archives	★ Came up in the 1920s ; when New Delhi was built, the National Museum and National Archives were both located close to the Viceregal Palace — " <i>this location reflects the importance these institutions had in British imagination</i> "

🎯 That last detail is worth pausing on. The archive was placed **beside the seat of power**, physically. **Knowledge and rule were understood to belong together** — which is exactly the argument of the next section.

🖨 The colonial state ran on **mandatory written logging of every decision, replicated and centrally retained**. It is an information system of remarkable completeness for its era — and like any log, it records **what its designers chose to instrument**.

📖 ★★ Surveys become important

★ "The British believed that a country had to be **PROPERLY KNOWN** before it could be **EFFECTIVELY ADMINISTERED**."

Survey	Detail
Mapping	By the early nineteenth century , detailed surveys were mapping the entire country
★ Revenue surveys	In the villages — recording topography, soil quality, flora, fauna, local histories and cropping patterns
★★ CENSUS	From the end of the nineteenth century, held EVERY TEN YEARS ; prepared detailed records of the number of people in all provinces , noting caste, religion and occupation
Other surveys	★ Botanical, zoological, archaeological, anthropological, forest surveys

★ ★ ★ **The census deserves special attention, because its consequences were enormous and it is heavily asked in GS1 Indian Society.**

Counting people **by caste and religion** did not merely *record* Indian society — it **reshaped it**. Fluid, locally variable jati identities (Class 7 Ch.1 and Ch.5!) were **fixed into countable, all-India categories**.

Communities began to petition for higher classification. **Caste became a national political fact partly because the state made it a national statistical fact.**

 **The act of measurement altered the thing measured.** Defining the schema forced a messy reality into rigid enumerable categories — and people then organised around the categories.

★ The "map as domination" point

James Rennel was asked by **Robert Clive** to produce maps of Hindustan. NCERT notes he was "*an enthusiastic supporter of British conquest of India*" who "**saw preparation of maps as essential to the process of domination.**"

The frontispiece to his 1782 map shows **Brahmans offering the Shastras to Britannia** — the image "*tries to suggest that Indians **willingly gave over their ancient texts** to Britannia... as if asking her to become the protector of Indian culture.*"

 **A picture doing political work.** It converts **conquest into voluntary entrustment**. NCERT's instruction — "*images need to be carefully studied for they project the viewpoint of those who create them*" — applies to the famous 1857 illustration too, captioned "Mutinous sepoys share the loot", in which "*the rebels appear as greedy, vicious and brutal.*"

3 ★ ★ ★ What Official Records Do NOT Tell

The heart of the chapter.

"From this vast corpus of records we can get to know a lot, but we must remember that these are OFFICIAL records. They tell us WHAT THE OFFICIALS THOUGHT, WHAT THEY WERE INTERESTED IN, and WHAT THEY WISHED TO PRESERVE FOR POSTERITY. These records do not always help us understand what OTHER PEOPLE in the country FELT, and WHAT LAY BEHIND THEIR ACTIONS."

The alternative sources

WHEN WE SEARCH ELSEWHERE, "we find them in plenty, though they are MORE DIFFICULT TO GET than official records":

- DIARIES of people
- accounts of PILGRIMS and TRAVELLERS
- AUTOBIOGRAPHIES of important personalities
- POPULAR BOOKLETS sold in local bazaars
- NEWSPAPERS (as printing spread, issues were debated in public)
- writings of LEADERS and REFORMERS
- POETS and NOVELISTS expressing their feelings

⚠️ ★ ★ But even these have a limit — the crucial caveat

"All these sources, however, were produced by **THOSE WHO WERE LITERATE**. From these, we will **NOT** be able to understand how history was experienced and lived by the **TRIBALS** and the **PEASANTS**, the **WORKERS IN THE MINES** or the **POOR ON THE STREETS**. Getting to know their lives is a **MORE DIFFICULT TASK**."

★ And then, encouragingly: "Yet this **CAN** be done, if we make a little bit of effort."

🎯 This is the same "silence of the sources" lesson you met in Class 6 Ch.1 and Class 7 Ch.5 — but **sharpened**. In ancient India the record was thin. Here the record is **enormous** — and that abundance is itself a danger, because it **feels comprehensive while systematically omitting the majority**.

★ ★ The sophisticated formulation for a Mains answer: *"The colonial archive is not merely incomplete; it is **structured by the priorities of the state that produced it**. Reading it 'against the grain' — for what officials feared, misunderstood or dismissed — is what allows the historian to recover the experience of those it does not describe."*

📖 A rich log is not a neutral one. High volume creates false confidence in coverage.

★ The two contrasting sources NCERT prints

Source 1 — Home Department reports, 1946	Source 2 — <i>Hindustan Times</i> , 22 March 1946
On the Royal Indian Navy mutiny : <i>"Bombay: Arrangements have been made for the Army to take over ships... Karachi: 301 mutineers are under arrest... All establishments are under military guard. Vizagapatnam: The position is completely under control and no violence has occurred."</i>	On a police strike in Delhi : <i>"More than 2000 policemen... refused to take their food... as a protest against their low salaries and the bad quality of food... One of the strikers said: 'The food supplied to us... is not fit for human consumption. Even cattle would not eat the chappattis and dal which we have to eat.'"</i>
Voice : administrative. Counts arrests, reports control restored. No reason for the mutiny is given.	Voice : the striker's own. Gives the grievance and the reason.

★ ★ NCERT's own activity asks you to compare them, and the contrast is the lesson of the chapter. The official report tells you **that** order was restored; the newspaper tells you **why people revolted**. The archive records the state's response; other sources record the cause.

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
James Mill ★★ ★	Scottish; A History of British India, 1817, three volumes; divided history into Hindu, Muslim, British
Mill's view ★ ★	Asian societies at a lower level of civilisation ; British rule would civilise India; urged conquest of all territories
"Colonial" vs "modern" ★ ★	Historians prefer colonial because there was no equality, freedom or liberty, and no economic growth
Colonisation ★	Subjugation producing political, economic, social and cultural change
Warren Hastings ★	First Governor-General, 1773
Lord Mountbatten	The last Viceroy
Record rooms ★	Tahsildar's office, collectorate, commissioner's office, secretariats, lawcourts
Calligraphists ★	Copied documents in the early nineteenth century ; printing takes over by mid-century
National Archives ★	Came up in the 1920s , sited near the Viceregal Palace
Census ★ ★ ★	From the end of the nineteenth century, every ten years ; recorded caste, religion, occupation
Surveys ★ ★	Revenue, botanical, zoological, archaeological, anthropological, forest
James Rennel ★	Asked by Robert Clive to map Hindustan; first map 1782
Sources' limitation ★ ★	All alternatives were produced by the literate

Traps:

- "James Mill divided Indian history into Hindu, Muslim and Christian" → **FALSE**. **British**, not Christian (*NCERT asks this as true/false*)
- "Official documents help us understand what the people of the country think" → **FALSE**. They record **what officials thought** (*also a NCERT true/false*)
- "The census was held every five years" → **FALSE**. Every ten years
- "Historians universally accept the ancient/medieval/modern scheme" → It is **borrowed from the West** and problematic for India

Mains

- ★ ★ ★ **Historiography/Essay:** "*Periodisation is an act of interpretation, not description.*" — Mill's scheme, its purpose, and the case for "colonial"
- ★ ★ ★ **Indian Society (GS1): the census and the hardening of caste** — how colonial enumeration turned fluid jati into fixed political categories
- ★ ★ **Source criticism:** reading the colonial archive **against the grain**; the abundance-vs-coverage problem
- ★ **Knowledge and power:** surveys, maps and museums as **instruments of rule**

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Colonisation	Subjugation of one country by another producing political, economic, social and cultural change
Periodisation	Dividing the past into periods with shared characteristics
Calligraphist	One who specialises in the art of beautiful writing
Archive	A place where historical documents and records are preserved
Census	A ten-yearly count of the population recording caste, religion and occupation
Survey	Systematic recording of land, people, plants, animals or antiquities
Governor-General	The Company's chief executive in India from 1773
Viceroy	The Crown's representative in India after 1858

60-Second Recap

1. **Processes have no single date** — nobody began drinking tea, or being colonised, on a particular morning.
2. **The dates we treat as important depend on the questions we ask.** British histories organised around eleven Governors-General left **no room for Indians at all**.
3. ★ **James Mill, 1817, *A History of British India*, three volumes** — divided Indian history into **Hindu, Muslim, British**, held Asian societies to be less civilised, and argued **British rule would civilise India**.
4. **The objections:** many faiths coexisted; characterising an age by the ruler's religion implies **everyone else does not matter**; even ancient rulers differed in faith; and the scheme exists to **justify conquest**.
5. ★ **"Ancient/medieval/modern" is also borrowed and misleading** — under British rule there was **no equality, liberty or economic growth**, so many historians say **COLONIAL**.
6. **Colonisation** = subjugation producing **political, economic, social and cultural** change. **Our Pasts is plural because groups experienced it differently**.
7. **The British wrote everything down** — memos, notings, reports — kept in **record rooms** everywhere, copied by **calligraphists** and later **printed**; the **National Archives** came up in the **1920s** beside the Viceregal Palace.
8. ★ **"A country had to be properly known before it could be effectively administered"** — hence mapping, revenue surveys, and the **ten-yearly census** recording **caste, religion and occupation**.
9. ★ ★ **Official records tell us what officials thought and wished preserved** — not what others felt or why they acted.
10. **Alternative sources** (diaries, travellers, autobiographies, bazaar booklets, newspapers, reformers, poets) help — **but all were produced by the literate**, so tribals, peasants, miners and the urban poor remain hardest to reach.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. State whether true or false: (a) James Mill divided Indian history into Hindu, Muslim and Christian periods. (b) Official documents help us understand what the people of the country think. (c) The British thought surveys were important for effective administration. → (a) *False — the third period was **British***. (b) *False — they record **officials'** views*. (c) *True*.

2. *A History of British India*, published in 1817, was written by — → *James Mill, a Scottish economist and political philosopher.*
3. Many historians prefer to describe 1750–1947 as "colonial" rather than "modern" because — → *Under British rule there was no equality, freedom or liberty, and the period was not one of economic growth.*
4. Under colonial rule, census operations were — → *Held every ten years from the end of the nineteenth century, recording caste, religion and occupation.*

Mains style

5. *"The problem with James Mill's periodisation was not merely factual but ideological."* Discuss. **(150 words)**
6. *"The colonial archive is abundant but not neutral."* Examine how historians read official records against the grain. **(250 words)**
7. Assess the impact of colonial enumeration, particularly the census, on Indian social identities. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name Mill's book, its year, and his three periods.
- Give three objections to that periodisation.
- Why do historians prefer "colonial" to "modern"?
- Name four kinds of survey the British conducted, and say why.
- What do official records leave out, and what limitation do the alternatives share?